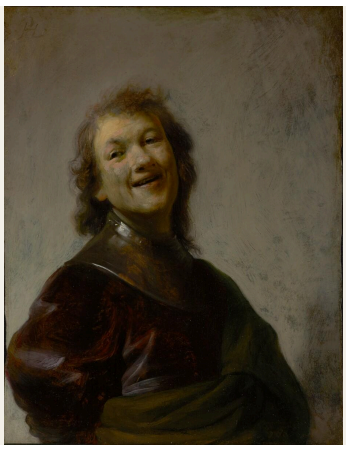
LOS ANGELES, UNITED STATES

J. Paul Getty Museum: Masterpieces

Twenty paintings in which appearances are arranged, interrupted or closely examined.



A laugh and a yawn are awkward things to hold for a portrait. Rembrandt and Ducreux make them the subject, allowing expressions usually excluded from a public likeness to take over. Elsewhere in this selection, an enormous red garment or a carefully furnished terrace gives a sitter the composure those self-portraits refuse.

The contrast is not simply between honesty and pretence. An apparently spontaneous expression is still painted and arranged; ceremonial dress can reveal a social role with considerable precision. These twenty works from the Getty offer ways to distinguish the person, the presentation and the setting. Landscapes and still lifes extend the question: what has been selected for display, and what remains just outside it?

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/getty-museum

The selection · 20

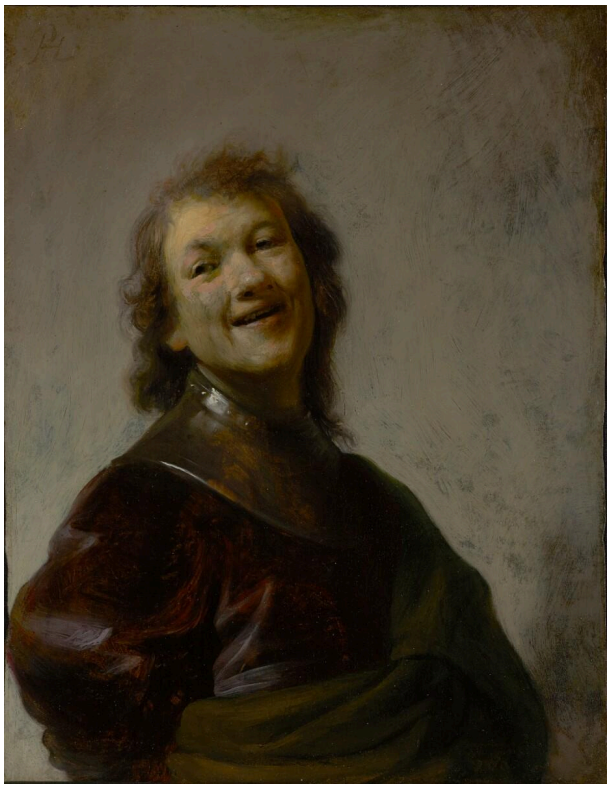
1. Rembrandt Laughing
   Rembrandt van Rijn · about 1628
2. Christ's Entry into Brussels in 1889
   James Ensor · 1888
3. The Rue Mosnier with Flags
   Édouard Manet · 1878
4. Wheatstacks, Snow Effect, Morning
   Claude Monet · 1891
5. The Musicians' Brawl
   Georges de La Tour · about 1625
6. Zénaïde and Charlotte Bonaparte
   Jacques-Louis David · 1821
7. Self-Portrait, Yawning
   Joseph Ducreux · 1783
8. Leonilla, Princess of Sayn-Wittgenstein-Sayn
   Franz Xaver Winterhalter · 1843
9. Maria Frederike van Reede-Athlone at Seven Years of Age
   Jean-Étienne Liotard · c.1755 - c. 1756
10. Alfonso d'Avalos in Armour with a Page
    Titian · 1533
11. Agostino Pallavicini
    Anthony van Dyck · about 1621
12. A Hare in the Forest
    Hans Hoffmann · about 1585
13. The Entry of the Animals into Noah's Ark
    Jan Brueghel the Elder · 1613
14. The Eternal Feminine
    Paul Cézanne · about 1877
15. Hunting on the Lagoon
    Vittore Carpaccio · c. 1490
16. Jeanne Kéfer
    Fernand Khnopff · 1885
17. The Marquesa de Santiago
    Francisco Goya · 1804
18. Study of the Model Joseph
    Théodore Géricault · about 1818–1819
19. A Young Girl Defending Herself against Love
    William-Adolphe Bouguereau · about 1880
20. Still Life with Peaches, a Silver Goblet, Grapes and Walnuts
    Jean-Siméon Chardin · about 1759–1760

01 / 20

Rembrandt Laughing

Rembrandt van Rijn

about 1628 · Oil on copper · J. Paul Getty Museum



Rembrandt Laughing. J. Paul Getty Museum; Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .

Rembrandt tips his head back in an expression that seems difficult to sustain. The short, uneven strokes support the impression of movement, while the metal gorget supplies a more formal costume. Painted on a small copper plate around 1628, this self-portrait brings performance and observation together. The apparent passing moment is the result of a very deliberate painted arrangement.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2013.60

02 / 20

Christ's Entry into Brussels in 1889

James Ensor

1888 · J. Paul Getty Museum



James Ensor. Christ's Entry Into Brussels in 1889. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Banners and emphatic faces press forward until the figure named in the title becomes difficult to find. Ensor makes a public arrival compete with the crowd's appetite for its own spectacle. Masks offer no simple distinction between disguise and ordinary faces. The painting asks where attention goes when everyone appears determined to command it.

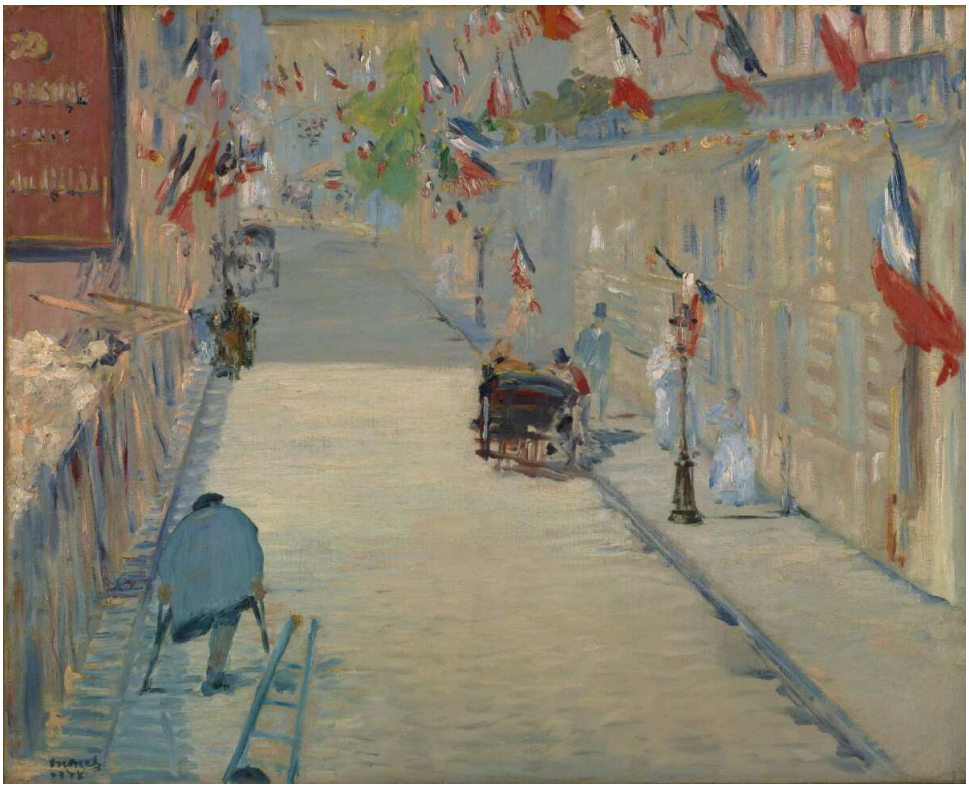
Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

The Rue Mosnier with Flags

Édouard Manet

1878 · Oil on canvas · J. Paul Getty Museum



The Rue Mosnier with Flags. J. Paul Getty Museum; Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .

The flags mark a public celebration, but the man on crutches at the near edge cannot be absorbed into a simple image of prosperity. Getty identifies the occasion as the national holiday of 30 June 1878. Manet places different conditions of life within the same street. The amputee may have been a veteran; the image alone cannot establish his history.

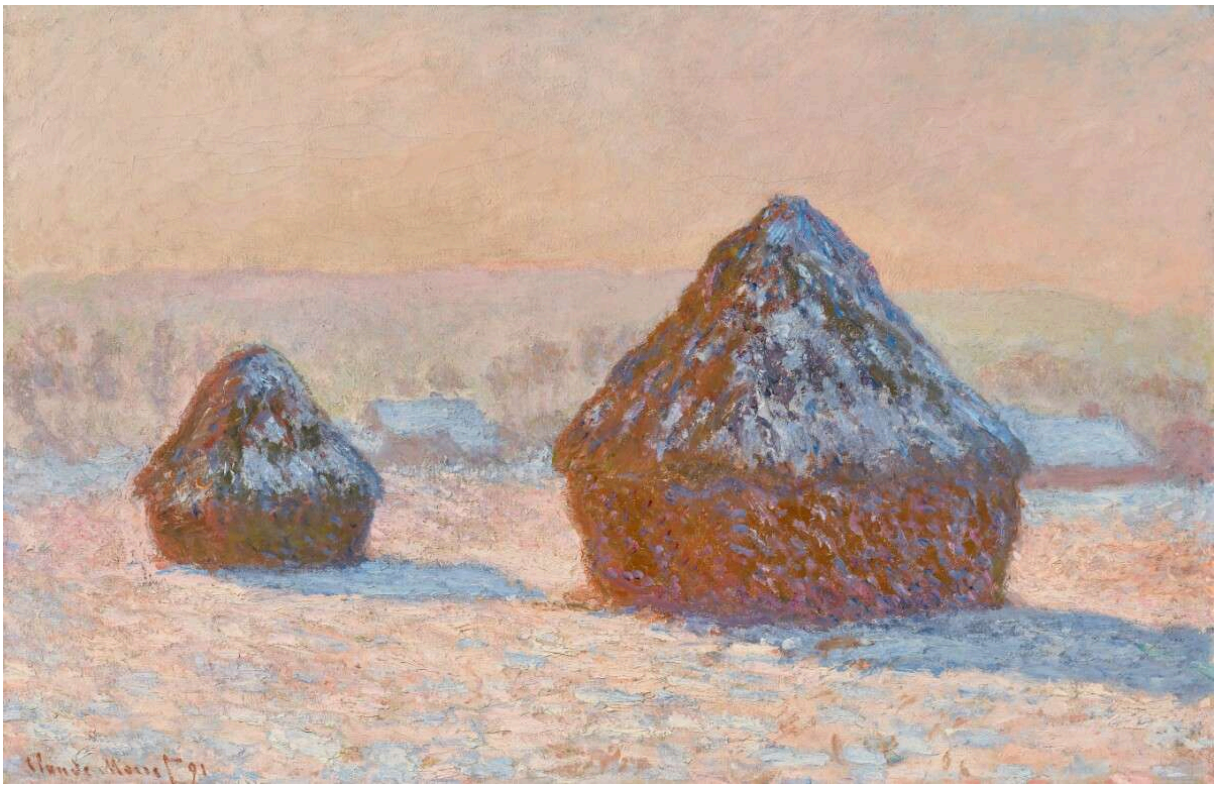
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 89.PA.71

04 / 20

Wheatstacks, Snow Effect, Morning

Claude Monet

1891 · Oil on canvas · J. Paul Getty Museum



Wheatstacks, Snow Effect, Morning (Meules, Effet de Neige, Le Matin). J. Paul Getty Museum; Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .

The stacks give Monet's changing light something stable to describe. Their dark masses remain legible while blue and pink shadows spread across the snow around them. What might otherwise be dismissed as a repeated rural subject becomes a way of measuring differences. The title's season and time are not decorative additions: they identify conditions central to this particular appearance.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 95.PA.63

05 / 20

The Musicians' Brawl

Georges de La Tour

about 1625 · Oil on canvas · J. Paul Getty Museum



The Musicians' Brawl. J. Paul Getty Museum; Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .

The instruments belong to one kind of coordinated activity; the pushing hands and striking bodies have turned towards another. La Tour compresses the group until there is little room around the quarrel. Faces and gestures must explain the interruption. Keeping the instruments in view matters, because they make the broken possibility of a shared performance part of the fight.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 72.PA.28

06 / 20

Zénaïde and Charlotte Bonaparte

Jacques-Louis David

1821 · Oil on canvas · J. Paul Getty Museum



Portrait of the Sisters Zénaïde and Charlotte Bonaparte. J. Paul Getty Museum; Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .

The letter gives the two sitters something to share beyond their place on the seat. David draws their bodies close while their contrasting clothes keep them distinct. A double portrait has to negotiate exactly that balance: two recognisable people and a visible relationship. Here a small sheet of paper connects the posed group to someone or something beyond the frame.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 86.PA.740

07 / 20

Self-Portrait, Yawning

Joseph Ducreux

1783 · J. Paul Getty Museum



Joseph Ducreux. Self-portrait, yawning. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Ducreux lets a yawn take possession of the whole upper body. The extended arms pull at his clothes; the open mouth refuses the composed expression expected of a formal sitter. Yet this bodily reflex is also a choice about self-presentation. The portrait demonstrates how convincingly an artist can stage the moment when dignified control appears to lapse.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Leonilla, Princess of Sayn-Wittgenstein-Sayn

Franz Xaver Winterhalter

1843 · Oil on canvas · J. Paul Getty Museum



Portrait of Leonilla, Princess of Sayn-Wittgenstein-Sayn. J. Paul Getty Museum; Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .

The reclining pose takes possession of a furnished terrace rather than merely occupying a chair. Winterhalter distributes light across the pale dress and surrounds the sitter with drapery, plants and distant space. Leisure becomes visible as an extensive arrangement of property and comfort. The face is only one part of the evidence through which this portrait establishes rank.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 86.PA.534

09 / 20

Maria Frederike van Reede-Athlone at Seven Years of Age

Jean-Étienne Liotard

c.1755 - c. 1756 · Pastel · J. Paul Getty Museum



Jean-Étienne Liotard. Portrait of Maria Frederike van Reede-Athlone at Seven Years of Age. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/jean-etienne-liotard/portrait-of-maria-frederike-van-reede-athlone-at-seven-years-of-age-1756 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The small dog gives the child's hands something living to hold amid the carefully arranged ribbons, bonnet and fur. Liotard distinguishes these textures without allowing costume to swallow the sitter. The turned face remains particular. Formal dress establishes how the child is presented, while the animal introduces a weight and a relationship that the clothing alone cannot provide.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

Alfonso d'Avalos in Armour with a Page

Titian

1533 · Oil on canvas · J. Paul Getty Museum



Portrait of Alfonso d`Avalos , in Armor with a Page. WikiArt; Titian. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Curved metal catches the light differently from the sitter's face, making armour a substantial presence rather than a shorthand label for military rank. Titian places the smaller page beside him, giving authority a human relationship as well as material equipment. The portrait's hierarchy is therefore visible before any biography is read: one man is presented, while another attends to him.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

Agostino Pallavicini

Anthony van Dyck

about 1621 · Oil on canvas · J. Paul Getty Museum



Portrait of Agostino Pallavicini. J. Paul Getty Museum; Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .

The red garment expands across much of the lower painting, almost becoming the sitter's architecture. Van Dyck brings the pale face and hands out above this ceremonial weight. Costume does not merely decorate an otherwise independent likeness. It establishes how the body occupies space, and how an individual can appear before the viewer as the bearer of an office.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 68.PA.2

12 / 20

A Hare in the Forest

Hans Hoffmann

about 1585 · Oil on panel · J. Paul Getty Museum



A Hare in the Forest. J. Paul Getty Museum; Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .

Hoffmann gives the hare a principal figure's place, then continues the close attention into leaves, bark and smaller creatures. The animal does not stand before a conveniently empty backdrop. The surrounding detail makes looking a matter of moving between different scales: the hare's body first, then the particular things among which that body has been placed.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2001.12

13 / 20

The Entry of the Animals into Noah's Ark

Jan Brueghel the Elder

1613 · Oil on panel · J. Paul Getty Museum



The Entry of the Animals into Noah's Ark. J. Paul Getty Museum; Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .

The ark supplies a destination for a gathering that could not be observed as an ordinary landscape. Brueghel spreads different species across trees and open ground, making their distinct bodies available for comparison. The biblical narrative gives this variety a reason to share the same space. Looking can move from creature to creature without losing the event that joins them.

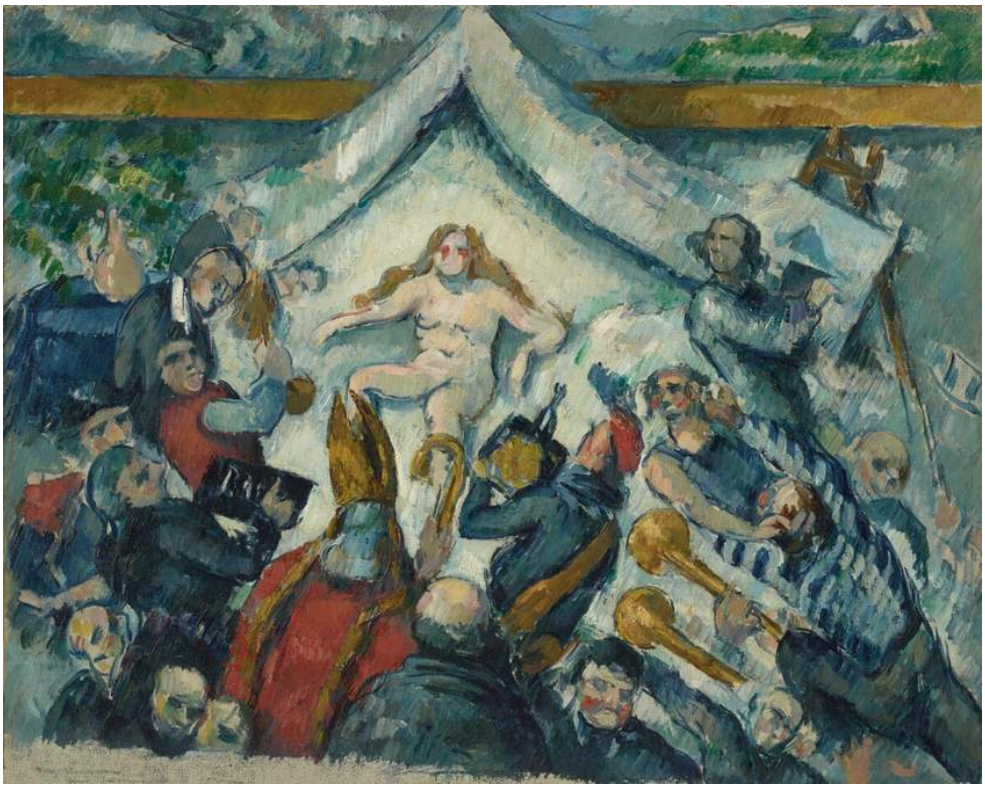
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 92.PB.82

14 / 20

The Eternal Feminine

Paul Cézanne

about 1877 · Oil on canvas · J. Paul Getty Museum



The Eternal Feminine (L'Éternel Féminin). J. Paul Getty Museum; Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .

The reclining woman is displayed above an assembled crowd, whose attention defines her role in the scene. Cézanne's abrupt colour and awkward forms deny the arrangement a polished elegance. The title is broad, but the painting presents a specific imbalance: one figure is exposed to many observers. Their looking is as much a subject as the body they inspect.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 87.PA.79

15 / 20

Hunting on the Lagoon

Vittore Carpaccio

c. 1490 · J. Paul Getty Museum



Vittore Carpaccio. Hunting on the Lagoon. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/vittore-carpaccio/hunting-on-the-lagoon · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Open water keeps the small actions in Carpaccio's boats from obscuring one another. Figures stand and aim, while birds, poles and the low horizon punctuate the distance. The hunt unfolds through dispersed attention rather than one decisive confrontation. Its measured arrangement lets the observer follow separate activities across a field that remains remarkably calm.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Jeanne Kéfer

Fernand Khnopff

1885 · Oil on canvas · J. Paul Getty Museum



Jeanne Kéfer. J. Paul Getty Museum; Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .

The large pale doors establish the girl's smallness before her age is known. Khnopff gives her a precise position against their nearly empty surface, with one hand drawn towards her chest. The architecture makes her stillness conspicuous, but it does not explain her feelings. It is enough to observe how a modest figure holds attention within so much unoccupied space.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 97.PA.35

17 / 20

The Marquesa de Santiago

Francisco Goya

1804 · Oil on canvas · J. Paul Getty Museum



Portrait of the Marquesa de Santiago. J. Paul Getty Museum; Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .

Dark dress and a pale mantilla establish a formal public appearance, but Goya does not allow that appearance to erase the sitter's particular face. The full-length pose extends her presence into the landscape behind. Social standing is clear; personality is less easily named. The portrait gives evidence to examine rather than a ready verdict about the woman represented.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 83.PA.12

18 / 20

Study of the Model Joseph

Théodore Géricault

about 1818–1819 · Oil on canvas · J. Paul Getty Museum



Study of the Model Joseph. J. Paul Getty Museum; Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .

The title preserves the model's name rather than leaving him an anonymous type. Géricault concentrates light on the forehead, cheek and open collar, holding the turned head against darkness. A study can attend to someone as an individual even when it belongs to a painter's wider working practice. Here the face does not need a larger scene to justify sustained attention.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 85.PA.407

19 / 20

A Young Girl Defending Herself against Love

William-Adolphe Bouguereau

about 1880 · Oil on canvas · J. Paul Getty Museum



A Young Girl Defending Herself against Love. J. Paul Getty Museum; Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .

The woman's arms keep the winged child away, giving the allegory an immediately readable action. Bouguereau's smooth finish makes the crossing limbs and drapery easy to follow. Cupid establishes that the encounter is an invention about love, not an observed garden incident. The scene's playfulness depends on a controlled contest of gestures rather than on uncertainty about what is happening.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 70.PA.3

20 / 20

Still Life with Peaches, a Silver Goblet, Grapes and Walnuts

Jean-Siméon Chardin

about 1759–1760 · Oil on canvas · J. Paul Getty Museum



Still Life with Peaches, a Silver Goblet, Grapes, and Walnuts. J. Paul Getty Museum; Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Images provided here are believed to be in the public domain and are available under CC0 through Getty's Open Content Program . Texts provided here are © J. Paul Getty Trust, licensed under CC BY 4.0 . Terms of use for the Getty logo can be found here .

Chardin places reflective metal beside fruit and hard shells without turning the ledge into a display of abundance. The restrained tones make small material differences consequential. Grapes trail towards the edge, loosening the arrangement without undoing it. After the elaborate costumes and public spectacles in this selection, a handful of objects offers a quieter test of how attention is directed.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 86.PA.544

Compare what the setting supplies

Place a formal portrait beside one of the expressive self-portraits. Which parts of the person's appearance depend on clothes, furniture or the gesture chosen? Then try the question on the still life. These works form a study selection; consult current Getty records and visiting information before treating any of them as a stop on a physical route.

Further reading

Dutch Paintings in The Metropolitan Museum of Art, Volumes I and II

Walter Liedtke · Read online or download · English

The Metropolitan Museum’s two-volume catalogue of Dutch paintings offers detailed comparisons for Rembrandt and the handling of faces, interiors and still-life objects. It is available to read online.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · J. Paul Getty Museum: Masterpieces